Samaddar. "Sprouted millet flours are more nutritious as well." All millets are not diet food either; 100 gm of bajra can be as calorie-dense as a cup of rice. A lot depends on how you cook the millet. Samaddar recommends eating millets with servings of vegetable and protein to improve the overall nutritional value.

The Ideal Indian Plate

Like with everything else, balance is essential to attaining dietary nirvana as well. Experts recommend that an ideal 2,000 calorie per day diet must have 45-65 per cent or around 225-325 gm of carbs, another 25-30 per cent or around 80 gm or less of unsaturated fat (transfat or hydrogenated fat should be avoided), about five portions of differently-coloured fruit and vegetables and about 10-35 per cent from protein (ideally lean in fat; seafood is highly recommended). Probiotics like fermented pickles, yoghurt, buttermilk are commonly available in India and also excellent for long-term wellbeing.

For micronutrients, a combination of fresh fruit and vegetables is a perfect elixir. A 2017 meta-analysis of 95 prospective studies published in the *International Journal of Epidemiology* found that each additional 200 gm of fruits and vegetables per day was associated with an 8 per cent lower risk of coronary heart disease, 16 per cent lower risk of stroke, 8 per cent lower risk of cardiovascular disease, 3 per cent lower risk of cancer and 10 per cent lower risk of premature death. "All vegetables are good for you and a powerhouse of nutrients," says Kolkata-based nutritionist Arushi Acharya. She recommends minimising starchy vegetables like potato and opting for different-coloured vegetables like purple cabbage, red lettuce, beetroot and so on. Dark green leafy vegetables, she adds, are particularly good for immunity-boosting properties. Acharya also tells you how to make even carb-heavy products like bread or roti nutritious—grate vegetables into them. It is also important not to overcook vegetables but lightly steam them to retain maximum nutrition value.

What about fruits? To have or not to have? Yes, they contain natural simple sugar (fructose), but their fibre content is such





> **"Millets have long been part of the Indian diet and have a variety of micronutrients that wheat does not, be it iron, zinc, magnesium, folic acid or calcium"**
>
> **-SWATI BHUSHAN**
> *Clinical nutritionist, Fortis Hiranandani, Mumbai*

MANDAR DEODHAR